

Episode 16: Once Upon a Time... (11) *"GeGeGe no Kitaro: Yokai Daisenso"*

The other day, Ms. O. from the records department (Toei Animation has this kind of position - like a script supervisor in live-action. Without these people, matching sound and image from editing onward becomes impossible - very important work) **came to me saying:**

"Hey, hey, look at this!"

What she handed me was a snapshot photo taken somewhere in the studio long ago. A snapshot from over ten years ago. And what was in it was me from when my hair was still short, before I started tying it back.

Man, ha ha ha ha (laughs).

The young folks who don't know how I looked back then couldn't tell it was me, and that transformation is quite amusing even to myself (laughs).

By the way, I actually applied for a passport at the Tokyo Metropolitan Government's passport office today. My current one expires in July. The photo in my current passport is from exactly 10 years ago, already with my hair tied back. But somehow you can tell from the somewhat unsettled hair that I hadn't been tying it back for very long. Over 10 years but less than 15? Well, something like that.**

10 years from now, when my new passport expires and I apply again, I'll probably think "Ah, so this is how I looked 10 years ago..." (laughs).

Well then.

A theatrical work! *"GeGeGe no Kitaro: Yokai Daisenso"* The *GeGeGe no Kitaro* that began broadcasting in the fall of this year (1985). This was the third TV anime adaptation, with **Toda Keiko** voicing Kitaro, **Ikuzo Yoshi** singing the opening song, and

the series where "**Yumeko-chan**" appears. This theatrical work was produced and released as one film in the "**Spring Toei Manga Festival**."

The TV series *Kitaro* had colour direction handled by a great senior, Sakamoto Yoko, who worked on *Tongari Boshi no Memoru* and *Magical Taruruto-kun*. Usually the TV series person would also handle the theatrical version, but I think she was also handling another big work? So it came around to me - that's how I remember it...

The theatrical version had an impressive lineup: Director Kasai Osamu, Animation Director Kanemori Yoshinori, Art Director Tsuchida Isamu. Hmm, I was thrown into such staff as a complete rookie (sweat). I remember being very nervous when I went to greet **Kasai-san** and **Tsuchida-san**. At that time, I think Kasai-san said "Let's make it a bit different from TV. We want to change the atmosphere from TV." Then I was given the storyboard to read, and indeed, it had a density quite different from TV. The running time was about 40 minutes.

The story involves Western yokai led by Baird arriving at the southern sea's isolated Houkiboshi Island with the appearance of Halley's Comet (!), and when a boy from that island asks for help, Kitaro and friends land on the island to wage a great yokai war. Yes, "Yumeko-chan" doesn't appear (laughs).

At that time, Toei Doga had art directors decide almost everything colour-related. Not just art boards and background paintings, but character colours were also specified by art directors in principle. We'd paint colour sample cels with specifications from art, then have character colour meetings. There, directors, animation directors, art directors, producers, and others would finalise colours.

Starting with Baird-sama, Dracula, Frankenstein, werewolf and wolves, and the village boy Akio - basically all were Tsuchida-san's colour designs. We fine-tuned them with everyone's input. Ah, since I was just a complete rookie, I mostly just modified colour samples according to instructions from Kasai-san and Tsuchida-san (bitter laugh).

However, while main character colours already existed from TV, given the director's earlier comment, I made colour samples slightly more subdued than TV with stronger shadows based on my thinking. And that was adopted as-is.

Based on this theatrical version's basic "colours," we had main episode meetings. Art meetings had already finished, so this was just colour direction meetings. "This beach has strong sunlight with fewer shadows, so high contrast" or "Kitaro here is near death, so make his skin colour earth-toned please" - I desperately noted the director's instructions in the storyboard. Making colours meaningful for characters, having characters act through colours. Happy moments during meetings.

Now we routinely do "night colours for night scenes" - changing colours to match background time periods - but back then character colours were normally normal-based regardless of time, maybe just varying shadow colour intensity. The "collaborative works" I'd done were all basically normal characters too.

Now, main episode cuts finally came to me.

Theatrical works back then basically all came to us after being properly made into in-between animation domestically. Man, that animation was good! The characters themselves were good, but the sharpness of movement was great! Just bundling in-between animation and going "para-la-la-la..." made me happy (laughs). The degree of character shadow amounts in each scene, properly calculated matching light sources (well, that's natural though (bitter laugh)) - I was excited about cel painting results.

Rocks, dirt clumps, construction site logs, breaking mansion roofs, water spouts rising to the sky, etc. - all background colour matching was also colour-directed by the art director in the style of that time. Properly deciding cel details like that was truly art director work.

And that art was wonderful. That's Tsuchida-san's artistic ability, that's theatrical work quality. My colour-directed and painted cels would go on those backgrounds, be photographed, become rush film for viewing. Well, it's the same work as "collaborative" projects, but thinking "it's a movie!" made it even more exciting (laughs).

In the main episode, there's a scene where Kitaro and Akio fight Dracula and the werewolf in darkness. I don't know whose animation (key animation) scene it was, but animation came up with normal + shadow having solid **BL (black)** shadows, plus lots of reflection light. At the time I still didn't understand animation well, and no matter how much I worried, I couldn't figure out what kind of screen it would be or what colours to use, so I took a whole bunch of those cuts to consult with Tsuchida-san.

When shown them, Tsuchida-san also found it a bit hard to understand, and what remains strongly in my memory is him directly calling the responsible key animator for meetings. Now I think it would have been easier to understand by looking at key animation rather than in-between animation. But back then, what came to finishing were cut bags containing only timesheets and in-between animation.

Thus, my first theatrical work *GeGeGe no Kitaro: Yokai Daisenso* was completed.

To write this, I brought this movie's video (I bought the commercial version as a memento back then) from my parents' house to watch. Amazingly, the tape was beta - what a surprise (laughs). But since I have a working beta VCR at home too (explosion), I could watch it properly, and man, it's pretty well done. Interesting!

In the ending staff credits, my name appears with the job title "inspection." This was because back then Toei Doga didn't have "colour direction" notation - it was strictly cel delivery "inspection," that kind of era. As I mentioned earlier, this stemmed from the style where all "colour"-related things were decided and specified by art (actually, our room is still noted as "inspection" in internal company notation even now (bitter laugh)).

Incidentally, among the finishing staff names is Itasaka-san, who handles colour design for the 4th series and currently broadcasting *Kitaro*.

Ah, it's fate, right? Itasaka-san (laughs)

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